WHY THE SCEPTICISM

Analysts have no doubt in their minds that while the recent thaw in India-China relations is real, it should not be confused with resolution. Kantha, who has spent decades inside the China desk of the external affairs ministry, adds a note of realism: "We are looking at stable and predictable relations with China. If it becomes constructive down the road, fine, that's a bonus." He is equally direct about what has not moved: "There has been zero progress on de-escalation. We have not even started discussing it in the past two years."

General M.M. Naravane, the former army chief who oversaw the 2020 Galwan crisis, concurs. "While troops on both sides of the LAC are disengaged, they have not been de-inducted," he says. Force levels along the LAC, he notes, remain significantly higher than they were before Galwan, and the underlying differences over patrolling rights remain.



"INDIA'S TRADE WITH CHINA IS NO LONGER JUST A DEFICIT STORY, IT IS A PRODUCTION-DEPENDENCE STORY"

AJAY SRIVASTAVA, *Global Trade Research Initiative*



ALAMY

TRADE LANE Launch of first sea cargo route from northeast China to India at Dalian port, China, Jan. 11, 2024

The phrase "early and significant harvest" is what has raised scepticism among experts if it turns out to be only a textual ruse with no change in what's being bargained. Saran recalls that China proposed an early settlement of the Sikkim sector two decades ago, and India resisted precisely because the 2005 principles envisaged a comprehensive settlement across the entire boundary, not a piecemeal one. Kantha agrees and recalls that India had proposed a package deal built on cross-sectoral give-and-take in its 2019 proposal, which sought to settle Sikkim together with the entire Middle Sector along the watershed principle. But China had rejected it at the time.

Both Saran and Kantha worry that resolving the easy stretches first could surrender negotiating leverage while leaving the more difficult disputes over Aksai Chin, Tawang and the rest of Arunachal Pradesh untouched. Menon distils the entire dilemma into a single, difficult question: "If you do all the easy bits, how will you ever solve the hard bits?" If one spends that capital early, India may be left facing Ladakh and Arunachal with nothing left to trade.

The outstanding issues, then, are not small. They begin with contentious disagreements over Aksai Chin and Tawang and extend to the unresolved question of troop de-induction, the absence of any real timeline for demobilisation and the strategic tangle of the Sikkim-Bhutan-China trijunction near Doklam, where any arrangement that inadvertently strengthens China's position could carry serious security consequences for India and Bhutan.

Then there is the word 'delimitation' used in the 2026 Doval-Wang Yi agreement. It may sound technical, but it carries real weight because the India-China boundary has never been formally demarcated on the ground. Delimiting stretches of the boundary, even the less contentious ones, would be a historic first, requiring political agreement on the principles to be followed. Delineation comes next: it is a cartographic exercise in which maps are drawn based on the delimitation agreement. Demarcation is the final step, involving the physical marking of the boundary on the ground, including the installation of boundary pillars and fencing.

Naravane, drawing on his own experience of commanding forces along the LAC, sees the intriguing possibility of the relationship shifting "from merely managing the LAC towards attempting pieces of an eventual boundary settlement". But he, too, insists that an early harvest must be read as a first instalment, not a final settlement, saying, "we have to do a package deal that covers the entire LAC. You can't just do what suits you and leave the major intransigent things for the future."

The honest assessment? While all this constitutes genuine, useful progress on managing the border, there is very little movement so far on resolving it. Both governments have also become notably tight-lipped about specifics: China's foreign